

the future, though, these capabilities will be extended to add on-the-fly installation for user applications, fonts, hardware enablers, and a lot of other features. That's something that proprietary desktops can't provide because their model revolves around selling software to users, whereas we're in the business of giving it away.

On the virtualisation front, we've made a lot of advances in areas like remote installation and storage provisioning. We're showcasing a lot more flexibility for administrators who want to go from bare metal to a complete virtualisation platform without having to spend time in a noisy closet with their equipment. I'd like to see a lot more people looking at the power and capability of KVM, which is the Linux kernel's built-in hypervisor. With 64-bit hardware becoming the norm, everyone's system is potentially a virtualisation powerhouse and we're going to be in a great position to tap that.

Of course, the advances we've made in PackageKit and in the virtualisation system pieces like *libvirt* and *virt-manager* are all run as independent upstream projects, so all distributions and users can benefit. I imagine that you'll be seeing these advances in other distributions soon enough, but the Fedora platform tends to make that possible through our commitment to leading-edge development through the upstream.

Q What's your opinion about Linux on the enterprise desktop? In which sectors do you find people are most likely to resist switching over from Windows and Macs? And what do you think the reasons are, behind their resistance?

As I mentioned before, I think the general-purpose case for proprietary operating systems on the desktop is becoming harder and harder to win. Information interchange becomes trickier, and vendor lock-in is too expensive a proposition for businesses that have to find a steady profit margin in a highly competitive, globalised market. Ultimately, I think there's a broad range of businesses that are served by integrating open source technologies at every level from the edge to the desktop, and one of our purposes in Fedora is to provide a wide proving ground for those technologies, whether they're targeted at the desktop user or the systems architect/administrator, and make them available to as large an audience as possible, for contribution.

Q There are some essential professional-quality software that are still missing from the 'FOSS desktop', viz. layout software like QuarkXpress and Adobe InDesign, that media houses like ours depend on; or there are professional sound and video editing tools that studios depend on. How can projects like Fedora, or FOSS heavyweights like Red Hat, encourage and facilitate developers of FOSS alternatives to develop something as good as the Linux (kernel), on which professionals can bet on?

By providing a robust platform for development, integration, and deployment that includes the latest

advances in tools and toolkits, and making it flexible enough for ISVs and appliance builders to develop cost-effective and innovative solutions for their customers. That's something at which the free software stack excels, and which we in Fedora and at Red Hat are constantly advancing through our upstream development model.

We can also advance by illustrating the open source development model as the best way to provide features faster to users and customers. Many software vendors that 'get it' are already moving to the way of doing business that Red Hat has been proving for years. They have a stream of constantly developing technology on the one hand, which feeds a stable, supportable branch on the other, backed by services, support, and training with extremely high value, for which users and customers are willing to pay -- and that puts them in charge of their own technology roadmap.

Q What's the road map of Fedora, and what can we expect in Fedora 11?

As we set the schedule for Fedora 11, we acknowledged that we were getting towards the time when Red Hat will be looking to branch our feature set for use in its next edition of the enterprise product, Red Hat Enterprise Linux 6. So there're quite a few features we want to get entered into our Fedora 11 release, and we track those openly and transparently, like everything in our project. Have a look at fedoraproject.org/wiki/Releases/11/FeatureList

That list changes over time as the FESCo evaluates developers' proposals, and makes decisions on how best to include that work in the Fedora platform. In addition, there are always quite a few features and initiatives that come out of our engineering-focused North American FUDCon conference, which is happening January 9-11, 2009, in Boston. I would expect in the weeks following that conference, that the list will be expanding quite a bit, but some interesting additions are the Windows cross-compilation toolset and the introduction of DeviceKit.

Q Thanks for your time, Paul. Is there anything else you'd like to share with our readers?

I have never been so excited to be part of free and open source software. I would encourage readers to not only use the software we develop, but to consider how they can get involved in Fedora to advance the FOSS ecosystem as a whole. Even doing simple things like filing bugs, fixing text on a wiki, or writing small tutorials, can be useful to hundreds or thousands of people. Getting involved in free software was one of the best and most fulfilling decisions I've ever made, and I hope you'll consider making the jump from consumer to contributor as I did.

Thanks for the chance to talk to your readers! 

By: Atanu Datta

He likes to head bang and play air guitar in his spare time. Oh, and he's also a part of the LFY Bureau.